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A Phoney Autonomy? Soviet Ukraine's Foreign Relations in Historical Context, 1917–1991¹

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On June 9, 1990, the British Prime Minister Margaret Thatcher paid a special visit. On her way back from Moscow, where she warmly supported the Soviet President Mikhail Gorbachev, the „Iron Lady” visited Kyiv, the capital of Soviet Ukraine, the second largest Soviet republic and a key element in Gorbachev’s plans to reshape the state according to the new ideology of *Perestroika*². Thatcher, like many Western pundits and politicians, did not expect Ukraine to become independent and did not support its quest for sovereignty. After being very well received by the crowds gathered along her route in Kyiv, she addressed the Ukrainian Supreme Council, the Verkhovna Rada. In the parliament, representatives of the democratic movement Rukh asked Thatcher what the prospects were for establishing the British Embassy in Kyiv based on Ukraine’s semi-autonomous status within the Soviet Union and its membership in the United Nations. „I can see you are trying to get me involved in your politics!” she replied with only barely concealed anger. Thatcher continued: „Embassies are only for countries which have full national status. Therefore, we have Ambassadorial diplomatic relations with the Soviet Union, with the United States, with Canada, with Australia. We do not have Embassies for California, for Quebec, for states in Australia”³.

The answer Thatcher gave to Ukrainian MPs is often cited as an example of short-sightedness by Western politicians oblivious to the winds of change that were sweeping across a gradually disintegrating Soviet empire. Just in one month, the Declaration of State Sovereignty of Ukraine will be passed (on July 16, 1990), and just in one year

¹ This essay is an extended version of the paper delivered at the 16th International Biennial Conference of Editors of Diplomatic Documents in Warsaw on June 8–11, 2022.

² More on the international history of the late Soviet Union see S. Plokhy, *The Last empire: the final days of the Soviet Union*, New York 2014.

³ Margaret Thatcher, *Speech to Ukrainian Supreme Soviet*, <https://www.margaretthatcher.org/document/108116> [dostęp: 4.11.2022].

the Declaration of Ukrainian Independence will be proclaimed (on August 24, 1991). Indeed, the strategic policy of the West towards the Soviet Union, and serious concerns about the future of nuclear weapons on the territory of non-Russian republics were an important argument in favor of Gorbachev's pleas for signing of a new union treaty. The question arises, however, why did the West never consider the possibility of the disintegration of the USSR along national lines? What was the extent to which the founding federal principle (or quasi-federal principle), on which the communists built the Soviet statehood, contributed to its eventual demise? Finally, how did such „latent sovereignty”, including the formal participation of Ukraine in international affairs through its treaty-making capacity, contribute to the fall of the Soviet Union? These questions were posed and loudly asked by Ukrainian and Polish émigré intellectuals even before the USSR disappeared from the world stage in the Cold War. Although they argued that the Soviet Union was in many ways a restoration of the traditional Russian Empire, they were also aware of its hybrid, and thus promising, quasi-federative structure. As a result of their better understanding of the USSR's multinational form, they were among the fortunate few who predicted the Soviet Union's end⁴.

The foundation of the Soviet Disunion

Soviet Ukraine as an element of the Bolshevik political project appeared as a result of the failure of several attempts to revive Ukrainian statehood after WWI. The Ukrainian Socialist Soviet Republic was formally established in January 1919 when a second Soviet Ukrainian government was formed in Kharkiv. However, it took more time to form a fully functioning administration⁵. The scale of anti-Communist resistance and the precedent set by various forms of Ukrainian statehood during 1917–1921 forced Bolsheviks led by Vladimir Lenin to make serious concessions to local Ukrainian communists, many of whom later joined the Bolsheviks as former left-wing leaders of the Ukrainian struggle for independence⁶. The first Constitution of the Ukrainian SSR, adopted in March 1919, defined the republic as an independent „state” within nine gubernias, which corresponded to the territory of its non-Communist predecessors. During 1919–1920, Soviet Ukraine and Russia negotiated their legal relations, and the union treaty concluded in December 1920 recognized each republic's

⁴ See for example: I. L. Rudnytsky, *The Soviet Ukraine in Historical Perspective*, „Canadian Slavonic Papers”, 1972, vol. 14, no. 2, p. 235–250; R. Pipes, *The Formation of the Soviet Union. Communism and Nationalism, 1917–1923*, Cambridge 1954.

⁵ S. Velychenko, *State building in revolutionary Ukraine: a comparative study of governments and bureaucrats, 1917–1922*, Toronto 2011, p. 167–172.

⁶ I. Maistrenko, *Borotbism: A Chapter in the History of the Ukrainian Revolution*, Stuttgart 2019.

sovereignty and their right to have a separate diplomatic service⁷. In fact, the Ukrainian People's Commissariat of Foreign Affairs had existed since 1917, and Soviet Ukraine inherited some diplomatic relations from the Ukrainian People's Republic. In Kharkiv, the capital of the Ukrainian SSR, representatives of Germany, Estonia, Czechoslovakia, Lithuania, and Austria remained active, and the biggest diplomatic mission was the embassy of Poland. Not surprisingly, the Commissariat of Foreign Affairs remained under the close supervision of the state security apparatus: Moscow spared the State Political Directorate (security police) to supervise its performance. It employed around 300 officials and had two regional offices in Kyiv and Odesa, an important port city⁸. In 1919, the commissar of foreign affairs became an influential Ukrainian Bolshevik of Bulgarian origin, Christian Rakovsky, who was simultaneously the head of the Soviet Ukrainian government. The appointment of Rakovsky, „the soul and real master of the Soviet Ukrainian Republic” as Trotsky called him, as head of formally independent Ukrainian diplomacy provided another trump card in negotiations with Entente, which had its troops deployed in Southern Ukraine. To counteract Ukrainian governments-in-exile, Piłsudski's federalist projects, and undermine the international position of French troops on the South, Moscow wanted the Kharkiv government recognized as an independent government on the international stage. The principles established by Woodrow Wilson as well as Ukraine's right to self-determination were cited by Rakovsky when criticizing French garrisons. In another note sent to the French foreign minister in February 1919 Rakovsky expressed the Soviet Ukraine's desire „to conclude a peace treaty with all governments, but on condition that the French government stops regarding Ukraine as a future colony for French capital, as another Madagascar, another Morocco, another Indochina”⁹. Therefore, the „bourgeois” influences in Ukraine were to be combated through the „bourgeois” concept of national self-determination, a concept Rakovsky was familiar with from his French education. To be sure, Rakovsky received clear instructions from Moscow on how to make use of the Ukrainian independence in foreign policy. By delegating broad authority to a Bulgarian communist without roots in Ukraine, Moscow did not have to worry about possible separatism, even in a Communist form.

⁷ J. Borzęcki, *The Soviet-Polish Peace of 1921 and the Creation of Interwar Europe*, New Haven 2008, p. 18–19; K. Wolczuk, *The Moulding of Ukraine. The Constitutional Politics of State Formation*, Budapest 2002, p. 45–53.

⁸ І. Матяш, *Іноземні консули в УСРР (1919–1922 рр.)*, „Міжнародні зв'язки України: наукові пошуки і знахідки”, 2017, № 26, с. 100–123.

⁹ Cite in: F. Conte, *Christian Rakovski (1873–1941): a political biography*, Boulder 1989, p. 151.

The reality proved more complicated, however. Over the next few years, the Ukrainian communists developed a framework that regulated the activity of diplomatic representatives of the republic abroad and foreign representatives in Ukraine. The Ukrainian SSR was a party to the Treaty of Riga, signed on March 18, 1921, which ended the Soviet-Polish war. Much to the dismay of Ukrainian anti-Bolshevik activists led by Symon Petlura, Poland has officially recognized Soviet Ukraine¹⁰. That same year, Soviet Ukraine signed several treaties, including ones with Georgia and the Baltic states¹¹. Following the signing of the Treaty of Rapallo between Soviet Russia and Germany on April 16, 1922, Ukraine signed a separate agreement with Germany, which led to the termination of official contacts between Berlin and the Ukrainian government in exile. It is interesting to note that Moscow was outraged by the demand of the representative of Soviet Ukraine Vladimir Aussem that Germany pays 400 million marks owed to the Ukrainian State of Pavlo Skoropadsky, the head of the German-backed conservative government in 1918. The Ukrainian envoy in Berlin claimed equal status with his Soviet Russian counterpart Nikolai Krestinski. Aussem signed an agreement with Greece, while his brother, Otto Aussem, represented the Ukrainian Commissariat of Education in Berlin and Prague. Oleksandr Shumsky, another national Bolshevik, was assigned to represent Soviet Ukraine in Warsaw, an equally important diplomatic outpost¹².

The Ukrainian diplomats made no secret of their desire to remain true to their own political agenda, which was not always in harmony with Soviet Russia's centralist goals. The Polish diplomats on the East became aware of Ukrainian Communist autonomist efforts. Kharkiv's desire to send a separate delegation to the Genoa Conference was seen as the first sign of growing strife between the two socialist republics. As vice-commissar of foreign affairs, Vladimir Yakovlev was evidently too open about Soviet Ukraine's hopes for semi-independence¹³. In the meantime, Soviet Ukraine sent its plenipotentiaries (*polpriedy*) to Poland, Germany, Czechoslovakia, and Austria, the main European centers of the Ukrainian exile movement. A half-fictitious international status successfully undermined anti-communist emigration's position. Bolsheviks presented Soviet Ukraine as a genuine national representation of the Ukrainian nation. In April 1922,

¹⁰ J. Borzęcki, *The Soviet-Polish Peace of 1921...*, *op.cit.*, p. 122.

¹¹ F. Conte, *Christian Rakovski...*, *op.cit.*, p. 158–159.

¹² С. Кульчицький, *Комунізм в Україні: перше десятиріччя, 1919–1928*, Київ 1996, с. 297–298; F. Conte, *Christian Rakovski...*, *op.cit.*, p. 158; J. J. Bruski, *Między ukrainizacją a rusyfikacją. Sowiecka polityka narodowościowa na Ukrainie w ocenach dyplomacji i wywiadu II RP*, „Prace Komisji Środkowoeuropejskiej PAU” 2009, t. 17, s. 8.

¹³ J. J. Bruski, *Między prometeizmem a realpolitik: II Rzeczpospolita wobec Ukrainy Sowieckiej 1921–1926*, Kraków 2010, s. 163–166.

Yakovlev said that one of the most important aims of Soviet Ukrainian diplomacy was to crash the international campaigns led by emigrants, so Western European countries broke off the relationships with them and reestablished contacts with Soviet Ukraine instead¹⁴. It was well known to Communist officials in Kharkiv that anti-Communist Ukrainians made desperate efforts to gain recognition from Western governments. In Washington, the Ukrainian People's Republic mission handed the State Department a memo stating that the Soviet Ukrainian government under Rakovsky was nothing more than „a local agency of Moscow”¹⁵.

There was the second logic behind the initial autonomist aspirations of the Ukrainian communists. Semi-independent status of Ukraine put an additional pressure on neighboring countries to which the Soviets had territorial claims. As part of this propaganda effort, the first collection of diplomatic documents concerning Soviet Ukraine and its relations with the neighbors was published in Kharkiv in 1921. Three brochures appeared entitled „In Defense of Soviet Ukraine” as part of the „Red Book” series¹⁶. In terms of theme, the materials concerned relations with Romania and with Poland, and included general historical materials about the relations of the Ukrainian movement with the „bourgeois” countries of the Entente. Given its propagandistic purpose, the collection of documents was eventually translated into French with a foreword written by Christian Rakovsky¹⁷. Ukrainian diplomacy, however, put eggs in different baskets. Aside from anticapitalistic propaganda, diplomats in Berlin and Paris worked hard to develop mutually beneficial economic relationships. Ukrainian commissar for education Hryhoriy Hrynko showed particular interest in German educational techniques and counted on economic cooperation with Germany¹⁸.

The first episode of Soviet Ukrainian diplomacy was brief. Already in the autumn of 1922, on the eve of the signing of the Treaty on the Establishment of the USSR, the work of the Commissariat was curtailed, despite the efforts of Ukrainian communists, particularly Christian Rakovsky, to maintain diplomatic relations within the scope of the republican government. Stalinist and Leninist centralism prevailed, and the demise of the Commissariat of Foreign Affairs was the final nail in the coffin of early Sovi-

¹⁴ F. Conte, *Christian Rakovski...*, *op.cit.*, p. 158.

¹⁵ Julian Batchinsky to the Secretary of State Bainbridge Colby, 12 May 1920, National Archives and Records Administration, Microfilm 1286, Roll 2, p. 278.

¹⁶ *В защиту Советской Украины: Сборник дипломатических документов и исторических материалов*, Харьков 1921; *Советские Россия-Украина и Румыния*, Харьков 1921; *Советская Украина и Польша: Сборник дипломатических документов и исторических материалов*, Харьков 1921.

¹⁷ *L'Ukraine sovietiste: quatre années de guerre et de blocus: recueil des documents officiels d'après les livres rouges ukrainiens*, Berlin 1922.

¹⁸ F. Conte, *Christian Rakovski...*, *op.cit.*, p. 165–166.

et Ukraine's autonomy. In September 1923, the Ukrainian Commissariat was finally merged with the All-Union Commissariat of Foreign Affairs. Among the remnants of the previous era was the Permanent Representation of Soviet Ukraine to the Government of the USSR, established in 1921. Mission itself ceased to exist in 1991, and its building now houses the Ukrainian Embassy in Russia.

After World War II

Only following the Teheran Conference in November 1943, separate foreign commissariats were set up in each of the USSR's founding republics (except for Russian), allowing them to engage in direct relations with foreign powers at least formally¹⁹. Oleksandr Korniychuk, Stalin's favorite playwright, became Ukraine's foreign commissar in February 1944. Almost no one had any illusions about the new „constitutional reform.” Ukrainian Soviet filmmaker Oleksandr Dovzhenko jokingly stated: „From Moscow's viewpoint, Korniychuk is an ideal figure, because any Russian is more of a Ukrainian than he is. And there is hardly anyone who knows less about a Ukrainian”²⁰. Ukraine's fictitious independence was used to strengthen the Soviet Union's negotiating position, particularly vis-à-vis the Polish government in London, in talks about the future Soviet-Polish border. The tactics worked, and some Western observers believed in the relative independence of the Soviet government in Kyiv. The eventual effect went beyond Stalin's expectations. In the summer of 1944, he decided to change the leadership of the Commissariat, replacing Korniychuk with former Communist International Secretary Dmytro Manuisky – a „fake Ukrainian,” as Stalin called him, a graduate of Sorbonne, as well as a very experienced international player²¹. Stalin wanted Ukraine to become a founding member of the United Nations, so he needed a skillful diplomat loyal to Moscow. The emphasis shifted from propaganda actions to international politics, in which Manuisky had even more experience than his boss, Vyacheslav Molotov. Despite initial claims to admit all the Soviet republics to the United Nations, it was eventual-

19 С. Віднянський, *Чому та як Українська РСР стала однією з країн-засновниць ООН? (до 70-річчя Організації Об'єднаних Націй і членства в ній України)*, „Український історичний журнал” 2015, № 5, с. 172–185.

20 Під софитами секретних служб (документи з папки-формуляру на О. П. Довженка), „З архівів ВУЧК-ГПУ-НКВД-КГБ” 1995, № 1–2 (2–3). It should be noted, though, that Dovzhenko quickly changed his mind. A KGB agent passed on his words: „Although everyone is happy Korniychuk fell through in such a disastrous way, I am not happy at all. I even feel sorry for him. In fact, it was not Korniychuk who fell through, but some very important political perspectives for Ukraine”.

21 P. Huber, *The Central Bodies of the Comintern: Stalinization and Changing Social Composition*, [in:] *Bolshevism, Stalinism, and the Comintern Perspectives on Stalinization, 1917–53*, ed. N. LaPorte, K. Morgan, M. Worley, New York 2008, p. 66–88.

ly decided at the Yalta Conference in February 1945 to admit only Ukraine, Belarus, and the USSR at large. Molotov gave the British example: those nations were no less sovereign than the British Dominions and had a right to representation due to their war sufferings. „It was superfluous to explain the size, population, and importance of Ukraine”, Molotov stated²².

Scholars have numerous explanations as to what motivated Stalin to pass a constitutional amendment and try to gain international recognition for two more Soviet republics²³. Additional votes at the United Nations were certainly a factor. The timing of the amendment seems to indicate that it was also designed to assist in negotiating new borderlines with Poland, which was to transfer Eastern Galicia to Soviet Ukraine. It could also persuade Roosevelt to accept the inclusion of the Baltic states by demonstrating that those states would have „independent” international representation. There was also a third major argument for the extension of the Ukrainian status – it could weaken the anti-Communist forces by showing that Soviet Ukraine was a genuine representation of the nation’s cultural and political aspirations. Stalin essentially explained this to President Roosevelt when he complained that his position in Ukraine was difficult and insecure. In a sense, Stalin found it useful to cite Ukrainian nationalism as a source of pressure allegedly beyond of his control to use as a bargaining chip with Western allies²⁴.

Since attending the San Francisco Conference in April–June 1945, the Ukrainian SSR has taken an active role in a few United Nations agencies, with the notable exception of the International Bank for Reconstruction and Development and the International Monetary Fund. Ukraine was even elected to the UN Security Council in November 1947. It is not surprising, however, that Soviet Ukraine played along the line drawn by Moscow: either on behalf of the Greek communists or on behalf of disarmament. Outside the United Nations, Ukraine has participated in a few postwar diplomatic conferences and has been a signatory to several bilateral and multilateral conventions. Ukraine was part of the peace treaties with Italy, Hungary, Romania, and Finland – former allies of the Axis. The Ukrainian SSR, however, was not invited to participate in a few agreements that directly affected it, such as the ones that legalized the incorporation of the formerly Polish and Czechoslovak provinces into Soviet Ukraine. In 1947, British diplomats in Moscow suggested to Molotov that Britain would be interested in

²² S. Plokhy, *Yalta: the price of peace*, New York 2010.

²³ See a good overview of those scholarly debates: A. Motyl, *The Foreign Relations of the Ukrainian SSR*, „Harvard Ukrainian Studies” 1982, vol. 6, no. 1, p. 62–78.

²⁴ V. Aspaturian, *The Union Republics in Soviet diplomacy: a study of Soviet federalism in the service of Soviet foreign policy*, Westport 1984, p. 102.

exchanging representatives with Ukraine to take advantage of its newly acquired foreign status. Molotov replied that Kyiv did not want such contacts²⁵.

In essence, Soviet Ukraine did not have diplomats accredited abroad and it was not until 1959 that the Ukrainian delegation at the UN established a permanent mission in New York. The republican Ministry of Foreign Affairs did exist, however, occupying a small building in the center of Kyiv. The Ministry's function was rather „ceremonial, ornamental, and symbolic”, as one U.S. scholar stated upon his visit to Kyiv in 1958²⁶. Ukraine's UN delegation consisted mostly of professional diplomats who worked on the same team as the all-Soviet delegation. Several Ukrainians held important positions in UN structures, including Petro Nedbaylo, who represented Ukraine on the UN Commission on Human Rights, and in 1967, was elected its chairman. Often, the Ukrainian delegation included symbolic „press the flesh” figures, such as prominent Ukrainian poets Dmytro Pavlychko and Ivan Drach, whose role was to establish relations with Ukrainian émigré intellectuals, either in New York or at Harvard, where the Ukrainian Research Institute was founded by émigrés in the early 1970s²⁷. Predictably, those contacts attracted the attention of both the CIA and KGB, which closely monitored such „transatlantic” connections²⁸. The era of Détente intensified these relations. During his official visit to the Soviet Union in May 1972, President Richard Nixon visited Ukraine, paving the way for a U.S. consulate in Kyiv. The West's attitude towards Ukraine's place within the Soviet Union was illustrated by Nixon's dinner toast to his Soviet hosts. Kyiv was referred to as “the mother of all Russian cities” by the U.S. president – a description fully in line with the KGB's expectations during such an important visit²⁹.

It was possible to further capitalize on Soviet Ukraine's semi-autonomous status when Washington and Moscow reached a détente. The State Department sent two officials to prepare for the opening of the Kyiv consulate in 1976. American diplomats

²⁵ *Ibidem*, p. 172–177.

²⁶ Y. Bilinsky, *The Ukrainian SSR in International Affairs*, „The Annals of the Ukrainian Academy of Arts and Sciences in the United States” 1961, vol. 9, p. 155.

²⁷ О. Аврамчук, „Український Кіссинджер”? Омелян Прицак, „реалітети” і проєкт „наукової офензиви”, [in:] Омелян Прицак: життя, спадщина, наукові інтереси: до 100-річчя від дня народження, Київ 2021, с. 111–112.

²⁸ *Report on the meeting held at home of Eugene Stakhiv*, 23 December 1966, Central Intelligence Agency's Freedom of Information Act, „Aerodynamic”, vol. 35, no. 0055, p. 3.

²⁹ *Toast at a Dinner in Kiev*, <https://www.presidency.ucsb.edu/documents/toast-dinner-kiev> [dostęp: 4.11.2022]. On the KGB „preventive measures” during Nixon's visit to Kyiv see: S. Zhuk, *KGB operations against the USA and Canada in Soviet Ukraine, 1953–1991*, London 2022, p. 162–171.

primarily engaged in cultural exchange and fulfilled ceremonial roles³⁰. Despite this, the Ukrainian KGB expressed great concerns with their activities and reported to the highest republican authorities on diplomats' connections with Ukrainian intellectuals in the United States³¹. The diplomat Ralph C. Porter certainly helped Harvard academics in their struggle with Soviet bureaucracy and security apparatus to bring Ukrainian scholars to America. For émigré Ukrainians, the working group to prepare the U.S. consulate in Kyiv was a source of information about oppressed dissidents, including Sviatoslav Karavansky, whom Harvard considered as a visiting professor³². The U.S. consulate in Kyiv was closed in January 1980 as a result of the Soviet invasion of Afghanistan, and Omeljan Pritsak, director of Harvard's Ukrainian Research Institute, protested the decision in a letter to President Jimmy Carter. Pritsak expressed „deep shock and dismay” over the closure of the diplomatic mission. „If I am not mistaken,” Pritsak wrote in January 1980, „the United States was the only Western country since the Second World War to have achieved the right to establish consular representation in the capital of Soviet Ukraine, the largest non-Russian ethnic minority within the Soviet Union, the second largest national republic, and a founding member of the United Nations”. From Harvard's perspective, keeping the consulate would advance Ukrainian-American relations. Pritsak hailed the two consuls, Ralph Porter and David Schwartz, for their exemplary efforts, describing the mission itself as „a small flicker of hope amidst the grey despair with which American-Soviet Ukrainian relations have been shrouded in the past decade. They appeared as a ray of light amidst the darkness in which the Soviet Ukrainian population has been cut off from contacts with the West since the Second World War”³³.

This „active” participation in international affairs since 1945 received propaganda coverage in several publications of diplomatic documents purporting to attest to Soviet

30 І. Матяш, *Іноземні представництва в Радянській Україні (1919–1991): протистояння і співпраця*, Київ 2020, 394–433; В. Чернявський, *Довгий шлях до визнання. Що передувало встановленню дипломатичних відносин між Україною і США*, „Політика і час” 1992, № 2, с. 38–43.

31 Спецповідомлення голови КДБ при РМ УРСР Федорчука В. В. на адресу першого секретаря ЦК КПУ Щербинського В. В. щодо проведення спеціального технічного заходу в квартирах співробітників передової групи генконсульства США в м. Київ, 30 квітня 1977, Галузевий Державний Архів Служби Безпеки України, ф. 16, спр. 1060, арк. 92.

32 Marilyn Johnson from the U.S. Embassy in Moscow to Donald Fanger, 24 February 1978, Harvard University Archives, Papers of Omeljan Pritsak (1961–1989), box 1.

33 Omeljan Pritsak to Jimmy Carter, 17 January 1980, Наукова бібліотека Національного університету «Киево-Могилянська академія», Науковий архів, ф. 10 (Пріцак Омелян Йосипович), оп. 1, спр. 984, с. 1–2.

Ukraine's sovereignty³⁴. Those volumes were brimming with phrases like „international connections of Ukraine” and „Ukrainian sovereignty”. It was necessary to cite the Soviet Ukrainian Constitution, adopted in April 1978, which not only guaranteed the republic's right to secede from the USSR but also referred to it as a „socialist state.” According to the Constitution, Ukraine was „a true expression of the sovereign will [...] of the Ukrainian people in *the field of international relations*”. The discrepancy between the theory and practice of Soviet federalism was alleviated by the Communist Party's unifying role and the KGB's omnipresence. Once those two levers lost their significance, as they did during Gorbachev's Perestroika, fictitious sovereignty grew into a truly effective mechanism of national emancipation. The Declaration of State Sovereignty of Ukraine, adopted in July 1990, just one month after Thatcher's visit to Kyiv, was drafted by Volodymyr Vasylenko, a diplomat advising Ukraine's Ministry of Foreign Affairs. The Declaration's section on international relations proclaimed Ukraine's „independence and equality in foreign relations” as Ukraine was a subject of international law. Ukraine's declaration of independence, passed after the failure of the August Coup in Moscow, referred to the right to self-determination laid down in the Charter of the United Nations, which Soviet Ukraine ratified as a founding member of the UN. Leonid Kravchuk, the head of the parliament and later the first president of independent Ukraine, attended the UN General Assembly session in September 1991 and used the forum to sell the idea of Ukrainian independence to the world³⁵.

In December 1991, the „greatest geopolitical catastrophe of the 20th century” took place – to quote the widely-known international war criminal. And despite all those commonplace comparisons of Ukraine to „California” (as Thatcher said) or „Pennsylvania” (as George Kennan once stated³⁶), and the completely misguided Chicken-Kyiv speech by George Bush-senior in August 1991, it was Ukraine, Belarus, and Russia – the three Soviet founding republics – that in Belovezha Forest in December 1991 put an end to the Soviet empire. At the end of the day, this phoney, strange or even fake autonomous status of Soviet Ukraine provided important legal foundation for Ukraine's peaceful – and no less important – fully legitimate exit from the USSR.

³⁴ Українська РСР у міжнародних (міжнародно-договірних) відносинах, 1945–1957, Київ 1959; Українська РСР на міжнародній арені: Збірник документів, 1917–1923, Київ 1966; В інтересах миру і дружби між народами: міжнародно-правова діяльність Української РСР, 1945–1972: документи і коментарі, Київ 1974; У боротьбі за ліквідацію колоніалізму : зовнішньополітична боротьба Радянського Союзу за остаточну ліквідацію колоніалізму та участь у ній Української РСР, Київ 1974; Українська РСР на міжнародній арені: збірник документів і матеріалів, 1962–1970, Київ 1977; Українська РСР на міжнародній арені: збірник документів і матеріалів, 1976–1980, Київ 1984.

³⁵ S. Plokhy, *The Last Empire. The Final Days of the Soviet Union*, New York 2014, p. 206–207.

³⁶ G. Kennan, *America and the Russian Future*, „Foreign Affairs” 1951, vol. 29, no. 3, p. 360.

Abstract

In this essay, I examine Soviet Ukraine's foreign relations between 1917 and 1991. Throughout the Soviet era, Ukrainian communists used the semi-autonomous status of the republic, embodied in its constitution and the founding act of the Soviet Union, to push for more independence from Moscow. Bolsheviks used the fictitious foreign policy of Soviet Ukraine to undermine anti-Communist émigré movements, exert pressure on Soviet Ukraine's neighbors and strengthen its territorial claims. After World War II, Soviet Ukraine became a founding member of the United Nations. A new period in the history of the republic's semi-independent foreign affairs prepared the ground for Ukraine's legitimate exit from the Soviet Union in 1991.

Key words: Soviet Ukraine, foreign policy, autonomy, federalism, Cold War, national communism.

Streszczenie

Niniejszy tekst jest poświęcony historii międzynarodowego statusu Ukrainy Sowieckiej w latach 1917–1991. Na przestrzeni lat ukraińscy komuniści wykorzystywali półautonomiczny status ich republiki, wyrażony w konstytucji i akcie założycielskim Związku Sowieckiego, w celu uzyskania szerszej pozycji autonomicznej wobec Moskwy. Dla bolszewików fikcyjna dyplomacja Ukrainy Sowieckiej służyła jako skuteczne narzędzie podważenia wpływów ruchów antykomunistycznych na emigracji, pomagała w wywieraniu nacisku na sąsiadów państwa sowieckiego, podtrzymywała skierowane wobec nich pretensje terytorialne. Po zakończeniu drugiej wojny światowej Ukraina została członkiem założycielem Organizacji Narodów Zjednoczonych. Ten nowy okres w historii półautonomicznych stosunków zagranicznych republiki przygotował grunt dla pokojowego i – co ważniejsze – prawomocnego wyjścia Ukrainy ze składu Związku Sowieckiego w grudniu 1991 r.

Słowa kluczowe: Ukraina Sowiecka, polityka zagraniczna, autonomia, federalizm, zimna wojna, komunizm narodowy.

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